

independence through policies such as the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020 and the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET). A reduction in the share of parliamentary seats, he argues, would exacerbate this trend, leaving Tamil Nadu with proportionately less representatives to advocate for its rights in the Lok Sabha.

In Karnataka, the Congress's Siddaramaiah contends that the Union government's actions—whether the skewed tax revenue distribution, inequities in GST (Goods & Services Tax) and disaster relief, an overbearing education policy, or arbitrary UGC (University Grants Commission) amendments—consistently penalise the state. "Delimitation is yet another attempt to weaken the South's representation in Parliament and stifle our ability to challenge the Centre's injustices," he asserts. Revanth takes it a step further, accusing the BJP of using delimitation as a backdoor strategy to cement its dominance by boosting seats in the BIMARU states while sidelining the South.

"Our demand is clear... Do not penalise the southern states [with less Lok Sabha seats] for taking responsible measures to control population growth"

M.K. STALIN
Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu

There are concerns that delimitation could enable parties with significant influence in the North, such as the BJP, to establish new strongholds. "Going by the extraordinary enthusiasm shown by the Narendra Modi government, it appears that the real intent is to punish the people of the South for resisting the BJP," says Siddaramaiah ominously.

It is in this context that the BJP's move to link the implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill to delimitation takes on added political significance. By making